

One Coalition, One Winner

Lesson 25 — Founding the Islamic Republic

What you will know and be able to do

1

Explain how a broad revolutionary coalition narrowed to Khomeini's specific vision

2

Describe the institutions Khomeini built to secure clerical control

3

Trace how the final constitution differed from its original, more moderate draft

4

Evaluate whether this outcome was always the revolution's likely destination

A revolution built from many hands

Lesson 24 left a coalition of secular leftists, liberals, students, and clergy united mainly by opposition to the Shah. This lesson covers how that broad coalition narrowed, in barely a year, into a state built on Khomeini's own specific doctrine alone.

Bazargan's provisional government

Khomeini appointed the moderate Mehdi Bazargan as provisional prime minister, reassuring Iran's middle class that the revolution would remain measured. Real power, however, sat elsewhere: with the Revolutionary Council and, increasingly, the Islamic Republican Party — bodies fully loyal to Khomeini himself, which Bazargan's government could not actually control.

The Revolutionary Guard, May 1979

Established on 5 May 1979 as a counterweight to both leftist militias and the Shah's remaining military structure, the Pasdaran — Revolutionary Guard — grew rapidly into the revolution's single strongest institution, alongside local revolutionary committees, or komitehs, enforcing order at the neighbourhood level.

From a modest constitution to a clerical one

Bazargan's own government published a preliminary constitutional draft in June 1979 that made no reference to velayat-e faqih, reserving clergy only a minority role on a guardian council. By the time the Assembly of Experts finished its work later that year, the doctrine of clerical guardianship had been written directly into the state's foundations.

August 1979: the press law, and a stark warning

Dozens of newspapers opposing theocratic rule were shut down under a new law banning “counter-revolutionary” activity; tens of thousands protested at Tehran University. Khomeini's response to the protesters was blunt: “We thought we were dealing with human beings. It is evident we are not,” he said, comparing them to wild animals and warning that such “corrupt elements” would meet a harsher fate.

The December 1979 referendum

On 2–3 December 1979, Iranians voted on the finalised constitution: official results reported roughly 75% turnout and 99.5% approval among those who voted — formally establishing velayat-e faqih, with Khomeini himself as the first Supreme Leader, or rahbar.

Allies removed, one by one

Bazargan's government resigned within the year; the republic's first president, Abolhassan Bani-Sadr, and leftist allies including the Mojahedin-e Khalq guerrillas, were pushed out soon after, accused of insufficient revolutionary commitment. By the early 1980s, the coalition that had actually overthrown the Shah had been almost entirely replaced by a single, clerically dominated faction.

Was this always where the revolution was heading?

One view holds that Khomeini's clerical state was the revolution's logical destination, given his doctrine's long development in exile. Another holds that a genuinely more pluralist outcome was possible in 1979, foreclosed only by Khomeini's skilful, sequential elimination of rivals — a live question about how much historical outcomes reflect deep structural forces versus specific political choices.

A full essay attempt

'An Islamic Republic under clerical rule was always the most likely outcome of the 1979 revolution, given the movement's underlying ideology.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence: the original draft constitution and the purges that followed
- Address the counter-argument that Khomeini's political skill, not inevitability, secured this outcome

Key terms from today

Revolutionary Council

The Khomeinist body holding real power behind Bazargan's provisional government.

Rahbar

Supreme Leader; the position created for Khomeini by the new constitution.

Pasdaran

The Revolutionary Guard, founded May 1979 as a parallel military force.

Sequential elimination

Removing former allies one at a time, rather than all at once.

What to remember

Khomeini used temporary moderate allies, new parallel institutions like the Revolutionary Guard, and a constitution that grew steadily more clerical between draft and ratification to transform a broad coalition into a state built specifically on his own doctrine — removing former allies, from Bazargan to Bani-Sadr, once they had served their purpose.

Lesson 26 — The US Embassy hostage crisis

Next lesson: the 444-day crisis that defined Iran's new relationship with the West, and its lasting cost for both nations.